THE GLADIATORS

Three former chief ministers, the incumbent and an aspirant—the five men who are leading their party campaigns in the three-cornered fight for Karnataka

Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**

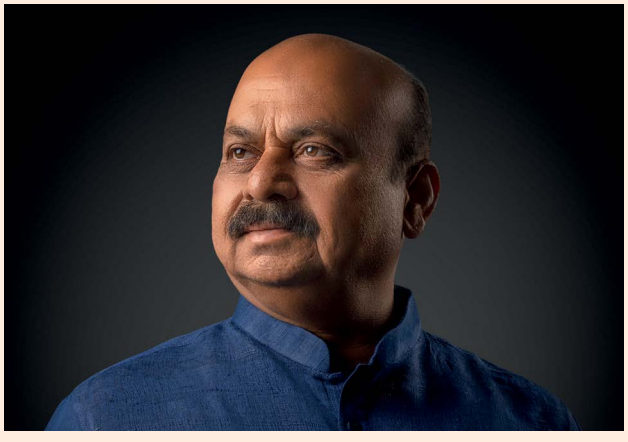


B.S. YEDIYURAPPA
80; BJP

This old warhorse may not be contesting the assembly election (for the first time since 1983), yet he's at the forefront of the BJP's campaign in Karnataka as the party mascot. "I may be 80, but I'm still strong," says the indefatigable campaigner who led the BJP to its first government in a southern state 15 years ago. He has been CM four times, though two of those terms lasted less than a week and the other two were cut short mid-term. Even in his electoral retirement, Yediyurappa's importance to the BJP cannot be understated. He still commands a massive following among the Veerashaiva-Lingayat community, the BJP's mainstay in the southern state. But the veteran's unfinished agenda, as he puts it, is to see his party come to power in Karnataka with an outright majority for the first time.

BASAVARAJ BOMMAI
63; BJP

A mechanical engineer, he has followed in his father and Janata Party stalwart S.R. Bommai's footsteps to occupy the chief minister's chair in Karnataka. Basavaraj Bommai, too, cut his teeth in the Janata Dal before joining the BJP in 2008. Since then, his career graph has risen steadily. He was water resources minister in the first BJP government (2008-2013) and then the home minister when the party returned to power in 2019. When Yediyurappa stepped down as CM in 2021, Bommai was his pick as the successor. Well-read and articulate, he's the BJP's "common man" CM. He also plays a shrewd hand. But no Karnataka CM after Ramakrishna Hegde in 1985 has led his party to a second consecutive term. Can Bommai break the jinx?



it, thanks to the social engineering that Siddaramaiah has put into place. Called Ahinda, a Kannada acronym for Alpasankhyaturu (minorities), Hindulidavaru (Backward Classes) and Dalitaru (Scheduled Castes), it remains the party's core strength. Siddaramaiah is a Kuruba, a dominant OBC group in the state that constitutes 7 per cent of the electorate, while Kharge is a Dalit, a community that has a 17 per cent share. With Shivakumar, who is a Vokkaliga, they also have a recognised leader among this powerful community that makes up 12 per cent of the electorate. The community it needs to focus on is the Lingayats, who have in recent elections backed the BJP fully.

On April 24, Rahul Gandhi was at the holy pilgrimage site of Kudala Sangama at the confluence of the Krishna and Malaprabha rivers in Bagalkot, for the Basava Jayanti celebration. Basava was the 12th century social reformer whom the Lingayat community revere as their spiritual founder and guide. Rahul's gesture came in the middle of his party's outreach to Lingayats. While allotting seats, too, the Congress has looked closely at the northern parts of the state, where the

Siddaramaiah is the crowd-puller of the Congress, but Shivakumar believes it is his turn for the top job if the party wins this time